

A photograph of the Helsinki Cathedral, a white neoclassical building with a large central dome and two smaller side domes, all topped with golden crosses. The building features a prominent portico with six columns. In the foreground, a wide set of stone steps leads up to the entrance, with several people walking on them. The sky is a clear, deep blue.

Language Guide

Finland Helsinki Mission

ELDER CODY DANIELS

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Tools of the Trade

Becoming a Quizlet Pro

Learn New Vocabulary

Getting to Know Quizlet

Quizlet is an Android application that allows us to create digital flashcards. This helps us to spend less time managing cumbersome paper flashcards and more time studying them. In some cases, we may not need to spend any time making them at all, since there is already a growing online community of flashcard content creators. The digital format also helps us mix up the way we study our cards to increase comprehension.

Joining the Mission Quizlet Community

Quizlet has a feature called "classes" that enables us to gather together as missionaries and share flashcard sets together. You can find the mission Quizlet class by searching for "Finland Helsinki Mission." Once you find it, you'll need to request to join under the members tab. As a class member, you'll be able to share your own sets and browse your fellow classmates' content. You'll also be able to find the class again easier, since it will show up on your homepage.

Studying a Set

Through the mission class, you can find a wide range of pre-made sets for studying. Once you find one you like, it's time to learn!

Cleaning Up the List

As you look at the terms list, you might notice some words that you don't find interesting. There are a couple approaches for fixing this. You could simply star all of the words you like and study only the starred terms. Alternatively, you could clone the set for yourself and remove the unwanted terms. The advantage to this approach is that you can optionally add your own terms and use the stars to mark difficult terms for extra study. However, you'll lose out on the social leaderboards.

Pretesting

Whether studying for the first time or reviewing for the seventh time, I'd recommend doing a quick pretest. Pretesting forces your brain to perform active recall. It also provides an idea of where you're at to measure progress. To take a pretest, use Quizlet's Test, Flashcard, or Write function. Ideally, change your settings to prompt you with the English term first. Otherwise questions will only test if you can recognize the word, not retrieve it. After you complete a pretest, you might star the words that proved extra difficult for you, so you can study them more.

Study Methods

Quizlet provides a handful of ways to study. The Learn mode is a good choice the first time around to build a familiarity with the words. The classic Flashcards mode is useful for a quick review. The Write mode is useful when you want to put in a bit more effort. The Match mode is useful for building fluency with new vocabulary, or learning to recall the words faster. It also introduces a bit of competition to see who can match the fastest.

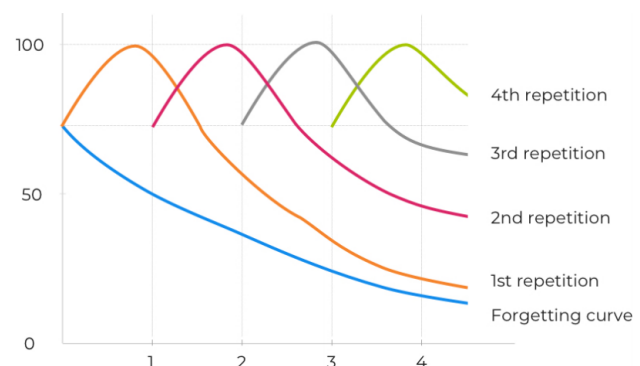
The best time to review a term is when it is hardest for your brain to recall it.

When am I done studying?

You'll know you're done studying a set once you can successfully recall all of the words from English. Studying any more will yield diminishing returns. Finish up studying by planning your next review!

Planning a Review

Spaced review is a crucial part of learning new vocabulary effectively and efficiently. The best time to review a term is when it is hardest for your brain to recall it. With each review, it will take longer and longer for your brain to forget, so you'll need to plan your reviews accordingly. This phenomenon is known as the Forgetting Curve, and looks like this on the right.



Spaced Review Planner

In the "Mission Language Tools" folder, I've created a spreadsheet to help you calculate and keep track of all of your spaced reviews. To use it yourself, save a copy of it in your own Drive. For a more detailed explanation of how the sheet works, check out the training video. Using it is completely optional, of course, but I think it makes it easy.

Language Study Challenge

- ☐ Join the "Finland Helsinki Mission" Quizlet class
- ☐ Find a set to study
- ☐ Narrow down the list to the words you care about
- ☐ Take a pretest
- ☐ Study the words
- ☐ Copy the Spaced Review planner or create one of your own
- ☐ Plan your next review

Getting the Nuts and Bolts

Master the Grammar

Grammar Learning Theory

There are two prominent theories about how humans learn grammar: rule-based and exemplar-based learning.

Rule-based Learning

Rule-based learning theory suggests that our brains store a series of rules which dictate things like word order and verb tense. For instance, something as simple as “subjects come before verbs.” But this is not always the case, such as in the sentence, “Here are your shoes.” The shoes are the subject, and they come after the verb, so the rule is broken. This would require making another rule or a special exception. Most language courses are structured in a way to teach us rules and exceptions like these. You may notice that babies don’t learn their mother tongue this way.

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example
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Exemplar-based Learning

Exemplar-based learning theory suggests that our brains store a bunch of example phrases and sentences that we use as patterns for new speech. To continue our example from before, we might learn the pattern “Here are your shoes” to create more sentences like “Here are your keys,” etc. I reckon that this is how your brain works when you speak your native language. That’s why certain phrases just sound right without being able to produce a rule to explain it.

Rule-based learning may be useful as a crutch when we first start to study a foreign language. However, if we wish to be proficient users of Finnish, we should aim for exemplar-based knowledge that gives us a real feel for what is right and wrong. There are a few ways to do this. Namely there are several Quizlet grammar decks found through the

Finland Helsinki Mission class to help you drill different grammatical forms. Reading extensively can also help you develop a library of grammatical structures. The feel will simply come from using the language, but the process can be accelerated with deliberate studying. It is the longer way, but it is also the best way with the best results.

Language Study Challenge

- ☐ Drill a Quizlet grammar set
- ☐ Find examples of tricky grammar concepts
- ☐ Learn to use "Better Sanakirja" to verify grammatical forms

Hitting Up the Library

Build Your Reading Skills

Applying for a Library Card

Applying for a library card is actually dead simple and free! Simply walk up to the circulation desk and ask for an application. You'll need to know your address, your phone number, and most importantly your henkilötunnus. It doesn't take more than a couple of minutes, and you'll have access to everything that the library offers.



Finding Something to Read

There's a lot of options at the library, and it can be overwhelming. Here are a couple of suggestions for those starting out.

Easy or Graded Readers

Easy Readers are designed for second-language learners to acquire vocabulary through context. They only use basic vocabulary with occasional new words for you to pick up. There aren't too many of this kind of book for Finnish language learners. A piece of Finnish classic literature, "Helsinkiin" by Juhani Aho, was rewritten as an Easy Reader, though.

Children's Books

Children's books are a popular choice because they are rich with pictures and easy to read. Your library should have a pretty sizable children's section. They may not contain the most practical vocabulary, though. Some Finnish suggestions are Tatu ja Patu, Moomin, and Koiramäki books.

Teen Audiences

When you feel ready to level up, try picking a book for younger teen audiences. Also preferably choose a book that you are familiar with, which should help with following the story. Harry Potter is the classic example, since they get progressively more complex.

Grammar Books

Some Finnish grammar books and courses have short passages in them. They may also be useful for grammar exercises and vocabulary lists, if you're looking for those. These books can get pretty expensive, but they're free at the library! Some examples include the

Suomen Mestari series and Eila ja Ossi.

Reading is great
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Church Literature

Don't discount Church literature! Since our base vocabulary is mostly religious in nature, this kind of reading is likely to be the most comprehensible and enjoyable.

Reading in a Foreign Language

Believe it or not, reading in Finnish doesn't exactly work the same as reading in one's native tongue, because we don't completely grasp everything that's going on. The same thing happens when we speak Finnish on the street. Reading is great practice, then, for using context to pick up the details that we miss. There are two ways we can practice reading:

Intensive Reading

Intensive reading is when you use a dictionary to look up every word you don't know. You may even look up unfamiliar grammar constructs, etc. This type of reading is best done when you know at least 90% of the words in the text, that way reading doesn't become too painful and demotivating.

Extensive Reading

Extensive reading is when you focus on reading a lot instead of understanding completely what is written. Ideally you read because you are trying to learn something from the text,

not just practice the language. This type of reading should be enjoyable and is best done when you know about 98% of the words in the text.

There is room for both intensive and extensive reading in our language study plans because they provide distinct benefits. Intensive reading builds new vocabulary and grammar knowledge, while extensive reading solidifies our existing knowledge and builds fluency.



Language Study Challenge

- ☐ Apply for a library card
- ☐ Checkout a book to read
- ☐ Plan a regular time to read each week

Putting Pen to Paper

Apply the Language by Writing

Benefits of Writing

At first glance, it may seem like we do not need to write a ton in our mission language. Writing, however, is an oft overlooked practice that our Finnish could benefit greatly from. When we write, we get to apply our language just as we do by speaking but in a much lower stress environment. It forces us to wrestle with grammar constructions and fill the gaps in our vocabulary while simultaneously strengthening what we already know. Writing works wonders for language production, including speaking.

Prompts for Writing

Finding something to write about can be tricky. Ideally, we want to write about topics that matter to us personally, that way we learn things we'll actually use and it will stick better in our minds. Examples include journal entries, meaningful stories from your life, and important ideas that you want to be able to share with your friends. You may also try writing the missionary lessons out in your own words to master expressing those concepts. Continue to write and rewrite the same ideas in new and different ways. For more of a challenge, try creative writing such as short stories.

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Seeking Corrections

Writing in Finnish is extremely beneficial by itself, but its benefits are supercharged when we seek feedback and corrections from a native Finn! Corrections ensure that we aren't teaching ourselves incorrect Finnish. This may be a good way to involve your ward or branch's assigned language teacher. The most valuable kind of feedback that we could get would sound like this: "This makes sense in English, but in Finnish, we would say..." We don't want to sound like translators. We want to sound like producers of Finnish! That means sometimes expressing ideas differently than you are used to in your native tongue.



Language Study Challenge

- ☐ Start a Finnish notebook to write and revise in
- ☐ Write in Finnish
- ☐ Get feedback from a native Finn
- ☐ Plan a regular time to write each week

Planning for Success

Create a Language Study Plan

Principles of Language Learning

Before we get into the planning, it is worth talking first about the principles that make language learning work. When you use these principles appropriately, your language study will become much more effective.

Spacing

Spacing out your study sessions will give your brain time to sort through that new information. Just like a muscle, it needs time to rest. The best time to review a piece of information is when it is hardest for your brain to remember it. Embrace the effort. See “Becoming a Quizlet Pro” for more on spaced reviews.

Testing

Every time you test your skills, they are strengthened.

A test could simply be just recalling a word that you learned this morning and using it in conversation. A test could also be a more formal exercise that you create for yourself, like reviewing your flashcards or writing an essay to practice a certain grammar principle. Apply the knowledge. Remember this: using your language strengthens what you already know and shows you where to improve.

Categorizing

Categorizing means breaking down the language into associated chunks. For example, instead of making a plan that you’ll study grammar, make a plan to study plural partitive or past passive. Instead of making a plan to memorize words, make a plan to memorize words about sports or going to the sauna. Categorizing helps your brain compartmentalize and sort through the new information better.

Learning
Finnish is as
simple as
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long time).

Variety

Your brain loves new and interesting things, so you shouldn't study the NUT case every day for a week. Mix it up frequently, and you'll be a more engaged learner. Variety is the spice of learning. Don't be afraid to adapt and change course either. Find what you enjoy.

Setting Language Goals

Learning Finnish is as simple as making a plan and sticking with it (for a *long* time). The best language goals and plans are self-guided. Pre-made programs and courses are nice and convenient, but only you know what you are interested in and need.

Assess Your Progress

Assessments are a great way to figure out what needs more work. There is a language self-assessment available through the Missionary Portal that can help you with this if necessary. It asks a series of can-do questions so you can get an idea of which language tasks are more tricky for you. Try to answer as honestly as possible. The final report even gives some suggestions according to your skill level.

The Four Skills

When setting goals, keep the four basic skills in mind: reading, writing, listening, and speaking. Each deserves its own attention. For example, reading Finnish will only improve your speaking ability so much. Only deliberate speaking practice is the best way to strengthen your speaking ability.

Preach My Gospel: Chapter 7

Don't neglect the tips found in the "How can I better learn my mission language?" chapter of *Preach My Gospel*. It contains specific ideas for how to memorize vocabulary, learn grammar, read, write, listen, and speak. Really, everything you need is in PMG.

Language Study Challenge

- ❑ Create a language study calendar with grammar topics, vocabulary topics, and activities that interest you

Summary of Resources

Tools of the Trade

Better Sanakirja

The “Better Sanakirja” spreadsheet allows you to look up accurate translations, definitions, conjugations, declinations, example sentences, and etymology information. It is a super useful tool for checking the accuracy of your grammar and building your vocabulary.

Mission Quizlet Class

The mission Quizlet class can be found by searching “Finland Helsinki Mission.” A majority of Quizlet sets from the class can alternatively be found by searching for the user “FinlandMissionLDS.” These sets are meant for building a solid foundational vocabulary and drilling specific grammatical forms. If you feel like you have exhausted all the vocabulary sets available, it would be best to start creating your own. Share them with the class!

Spaced Review Planner

The “Spaced Review Planner” spreadsheet allows you to keep track of your vocabulary sets for more efficient reviews. It notifies you when to review which sets. There are some preset review intervals, but there is nothing inherently magical about them. If you feel like you learn faster or slower, adjust them accordingly.

Mission Trainings

The “Mission Trainings” folder contains all of the language moment presentations given at mission-wide webinars. There are many good explanations and other content in there to enlighten your studies.

Other Drive Materials

The “Mission Language Tools” shared drive is full of content to explore and study. You can find it through your area email’s Google Drive account. It contains grammar notes, Finnish-language content, study plans, and more! Make sure to familiarize yourself with everything. It may even be worth checking back for updates.